

ELITE PUBLISHING

THE WORLD: COUNTRIES & FLAGS

A Coloring Journal for the Places You've Visited

DECISIONS CONFIRMED FOR PHASE 2

September 2026

Thank you for your answers to the six questions we set out in August. Every one of them is now decided, and this document records the decisions in the same order, so that it can serve as the single reference for Phase 2. Where your answer confirmed our recommendation, the reasoning has been kept; where you refined it, the refinement is written in.

One item still depends on numbers we do not yet have — the printer quotations at item 1. It does not stop the editorial work. At the end of the document are the six sample country pages, written as finished pages.

1. PRODUCTION ROUTE: PREMIUM OFFSET FIRST

The question. The premium specification in the brief — linen, gold foil, thread-sewn lay-flat binding, the selected cream stock — describes an offset-printed book. A print-on-demand edition is a different object at a different price.

The decision. The first edition is the premium offset edition, to that specification in full. A print-on-demand edition remains possible, but only as a later, lower-specification edition, introduced if demand for the premium edition supports it. The two are not launched together.

Next step. Three printer quotations: one European house, one Polish or Baltic house, one Far East house, each at 1,000, 1,500 and 3,000 copies. The printer and the run length are then decided on the numbers, as you said you wanted.

Retail price and manufacturing cost. These are two different figures and are kept apart throughout. The 35 to 45 euro figure in the blueprint is the retail price the finished book can carry in a bookshop. The manufacturing cost is what the printer charges to produce each copy; it moves substantially with run length, paper availability and territory, and the only honest number is a real quotation. The quotations will give the manufacturing cost; they do not change the retail price.

Why premium first. Offering a cheaper and a premium version is a normal publishing pattern, but almost never at the same moment. Launching both together splits one audience across two listings and makes the premium edition look overpriced next to its own cheaper twin. The usual sequence is premium first, then a lower-specification edition later if demand supports it.

For the quotations. Printers in mainland China have in the past refused files over the treatment of Taiwan on world maps. It does not change our editorial position, but it may narrow where the book can be printed, and it should be raised with the Far East house when the files are quoted.

What it affects. The printer decision does not block the writing. It does block the commissioning of the illustration, which at 585 drawings is the longest lead time in the project.

2. THE COUNTRY'S NAME IN ITS OWN LANGUAGE

The question. Whether each country page carries its name in its own language alongside the English name.

The decision. Kept on every country page, beside the English name. It is printed by us, not left as a blank line for the reader to complete.

Why. It is the single strongest signal on the page that this is an atlas rather than an activity book, and it is the kind of detail reviewers quote. A blank line would stay empty on almost every page, because the reader does not know the answer, and a journal that asks its owner to finish the publisher's work reads as unfinished rather than generous.

What it requires. A native-reader proof of the roughly fifty names in non-Latin scripts before files go to the printer — a small, one-off, quotable line in the budget. Where a country's own name is the English name, as for the United States and Australia, the line carries the country's full official name, so that it never simply repeats the heading. Two of the six sample pages, Japan and Egypt, carry the first non-Latin names and go into that proof.

3. THE FACT REGISTER AND THE NATIONAL ANIMAL

The question. The national animal should appear only where an official designation exists. As a sixth fact, that would leave the register with a gap on roughly two pages in three, and a register that is sometimes six lines and sometimes five reads as a mistake rather than a decision, 195 times over.

The decision. The printed fact register is fixed at exactly five facts on every country page, always in this order:

- Capital
- Population
- Language
- Area
- Currency

There is no sixth field for the national animal. Instead, where a country has an officially designated national animal, that animal is the subject of the page's line illustration and carries a short caption naming it. Where it does not, the

illustration is an appropriate landmark or characteristic object. No national animal is ever invented or assumed to fill the space.

What counts as official. A designation made by law, decree or other act of the state. A popular emblem, an animal that appears only as a heraldic figure on a coat of arms, or a choice made by a society or the press does not qualify. Where a country has more than one officially designated animal, one is chosen for the drawing and the caption names it. The sample pages show each case: the bald eagle for the United States, the rufous-bellied thrush for Brazil, and a landmark for Italy, Japan, Egypt and Australia, none of which has an officially designated national animal.

Why. The register never varies, nothing is invented to fill space, and the illustrator receives a brief decided by the facts rather than by taste. It also gives the reader more than a data line: coloring the animal teaches more than reading its name beside a small icon.

4. FLAG COLORS AND THE FLAG REFERENCE SECTION

The question. Your color-dot solution for the country pages is adopted. The question was what then happens to the eight-page flag reference section at the back of the book.

The decision. The color dots stay on every country page, ordered in the flag's own reading order rather than scattered as a palette, which turns them from a list of colors into an instruction. The flag reference section at the back is kept, reduced from eight pages to four, and changes what it does: it stops describing color and describes arrangement.

The reading order. The dots read the flag the way the page is read. Vertical bands run from the hoist (the side nearest the pole) to the fly; horizontal bands run from top to bottom; the field comes first, then the canton, emblem or other elements in the order they sit. Each color appears once, at its first appearance. Italy therefore reads green, white, red; the United States reads red, white, blue.

The four pages. The section explains which band is which and how the flag is built, and gives its space above all to flags carrying coats of arms, seals, inscriptions or complex symbols. Flags whose arrangement the dots already make plain take a single short line.

Why. Dots tell the reader which colors a flag contains. They cannot tell them which band is which, and they cannot describe a flag that carries a coat of arms, a seal or an inscription. Belize, Mexico, Turkmenistan, Ecuador, Sri Lanka, Saudi Arabia and around fifty others fall into that group, and those are exactly the pages that most reward being colored well. Four pages is enough, and the four pages saved go a long way toward paying for the new sections.

5. “WHERE I GO NEXT”

The question. With the continent bucket lists added, the book had three forward-looking lists: the hundred-destination list near the front, the bucket lists in the body, and this section at the back. Two is a structure. Three is a repetition the reader will notice.

The decision. It is no longer a list of any kind. “Where I Go Next” becomes a practical planning page for one upcoming journey, with space for:

- Destination
- When
- Who I am going with
- Purpose of the journey
- Three things to arrange before traveling

Why. It becomes genuinely different from the hundred-destination list and the continent bucket lists, and it ends the book on a departure rather than a summary. A journal that ends with a plan is the one that gets bought again as a gift.

6. THE FAVORITE MEMORY SPREAD

The question. One spread in the back matter, or one at the end of every continent.

The decision. One Favorite Memory spread, in the back matter. There is no separate Favorite Memory spread after each continent.

Why. Six favorite memories are not six times as moving as one, and the achievement page closing each continent already carries a short memory prompt. Further full spreads would repeat it.

7. SIGNATURE EXPERIENCES

The question. You raised the possibility of one signature experience for every country — Japan, see the cherry blossoms in Kyoto.

The decision. No suggested experience appears on any country page. The country page stays focused on documenting the reader’s own experience. Curated experiences live in the six continent bucket lists instead, at approximately fifteen each: around ninety in total.

Why. Every other element on the country page records what you did; a printed experience tells you what you should have done, which sits awkwardly under an epigraph about the world as you found it. It is also 195 more facts that can go wrong, and this kind ages fastest — venues close, festivals move, sites restrict access. A single suggestion in the wrong category is the sort of thing that gets

photographed and posted, and the whole book carries the cost. And there is no room left on the page that does not come out of the white space, which is doing the luxury signaling.

The value is not lost. Ninety curated experiences, researched once, spread deliberately across countries rather than clustered in the famous three, sit in a section where a suggestion is the point rather than an intrusion.

SETTLED, AND ALREADY IN THE WORK

- 2025 as the single reference year for all statistical figures, with a dated explanatory note on the copyright page.
- Metric and imperial measurements together throughout, metric first.
- American English throughout, in prose and in the country data.
- United Nations treatment of disputed borders, with short factual notes in small type where required.
- An achievement page closing every continent, absorbed into the existing allocation at no page cost, each with a short memory prompt.
- The continent bucket lists, the expanded travel statistics ledger, and the Top Five spread.
- Your original line as the main epigraph.
- The Melville quotation on the quiet page immediately before the first continent, so the book has two quiet moments instead of one.

EXTENT

The target extent is approximately 288 pages, one signature above the 272 you approved. The four pages saved in the flag reference section go toward the sections added since Phase 1, so the decisions above are absorbed without raising the count further; keeping a single Favorite Memory spread rather than one per continent also avoids adding pages. Nothing already in the book is removed merely to shorten it. On the specified paper, 288 pages is a spine of roughly 30 to 32 mm (about 1¼ in) — neither thin nor thick, which was your requirement. The exact figure comes with the revised page map.

SAMPLE COUNTRY PAGES

The six pages below are written as finished pages: Italy, Japan, the United States, Brazil, Egypt and Australia. Each was chosen to test a different problem the page has to survive across all 195 countries, and a short note after each one says what it tests. Every country page follows the same order:

- The country's name in English, and its name in its own language.
- The fact register: Capital, Population, Language, Area, Currency. 2025 figures, area in metric and imperial.
- The flag to color, with the color dots beneath it in reading order.
- The line illustration, with its caption: the officially designated national animal where there is one, otherwise a landmark or characteristic object.
- A border note in small type, only where the United Nations treatment of a disputed border requires one.
- The journal lines, identical on every page, where the reader records their own visit.

Figures are 2025 values. Before files go to press, each is checked once more against the source set named in the copyright-page note, and the Japanese and Arabic names go to the native-reader proof.

ITALY

Italia

CAPITAL	Rome
POPULATION	58.9 million
LANGUAGE	Italian
AREA	302,068 km ² (116,629 sq mi)
CURRENCY	Euro (€)

Flag. ● Green ○ White ● Red

Flag reference section entry: *Three vertical bands, read from the hoist.*

Illustration. The Colosseum, Rome, in clean line for coloring.

Caption: *The Colosseum, Rome*

Why this subject (not printed): The Italian wolf is often called Italy's national animal, but it has no official designation, so the drawing is a landmark.

Journal lines

When I went _____

Who I went with _____

Where I went _____

What I will remember _____

What this page tests. *The simplest case, used as the baseline for the grid: a Latin-script own name close to the English one, a three-band flag the dots describe completely, and the most familiar trap in the illustration rule — a popular unofficial animal.*

JAPAN

日本

CAPITAL	Tokyo
POPULATION	123.6 million
LANGUAGE	Japanese
AREA	377,975 km ² (145,937 sq mi)
CURRENCY	Yen (¥)

Flag. ○ White ● Red

Flag reference section entry: *A red disc centered on a white field.*

Illustration. Mount Fuji, in clean line for coloring.

Caption: *Mount Fuji*

Why this subject (not printed): The green pheasant is often called Japan's national bird, but it was named by the Ornithological Society of Japan in 1947, not by the state, so the drawing is a landmark.

Border note, printed in small type: Japan also claims the southern Kuril Islands, administered by Russia, and Liancourt Rocks, administered by the Republic of Korea. The Senkaku Islands, administered by Japan, are claimed by China.

Journal lines

When I went _____

Who I went with _____

Where I went _____

What I will remember _____

What this page tests. *A non-Latin script in the own-name line, set at the same size and weight as a Latin name; a two-color flag, the shortest possible dot line; and a border note carrying three disputes in two lines of small type. At fact-check, the area figure is confirmed against the book's single area source, including whether it counts the claimed islands, and the Senkaku wording is aligned with the book's treatment of Taiwan.*

UNITED STATES

United States of America

CAPITAL	Washington, D.C.
POPULATION	341.8 million
LANGUAGE	English
AREA	9,833,517 km ² (3,796,742 sq mi)
CURRENCY	US dollar (\$)

Flag. ● Red ○ White ● Blue

Flag reference section entry: *Thirteen stripes, red at top and bottom; a blue canton with fifty white stars.*

Illustration. A bald eagle, wings half open, in clean line for coloring.

Caption: *Bald eagle, national bird of the United States*

Why this subject (not printed): The bald eagle has been the national emblem since 1782 and was designated the national bird by law in 2024. The American bison is also official, as national mammal since 2016; one animal is drawn per page, and the eagle is the older designation.

Journal lines

When I went _____

Who I went with _____

Where I went _____

What I will remember _____

What this page tests. *A country whose own name is the English name, so the second line carries the full official name; metric kept first even where imperial is the home system; a flag whose field and canton must be read in order; and a country with more than one officially designated animal.*

BRAZIL

Brasil

CAPITAL	Brasília
POPULATION	213.4 million
LANGUAGE	Portuguese
AREA	8,515,767 km ² (3,287,956 sq mi)
CURRENCY	Brazilian real (R\$)

Flag. ● Green ● Yellow ● Blue ○ White

Flag reference section entry: *A yellow rhombus on a green field, a blue celestial globe with white stars, and a white band bearing the motto in green.*

Illustration. A rufous-bellied thrush perched on a branch, in clean line for coloring.

Caption: *Rufous-bellied thrush (sabiá-laranjeira), national bird of Brazil*

Why this subject (not printed): The rufous-bellied thrush was designated by presidential decree in 2002. The jaguar, the macaw and the toucan are more familiar, but none is officially designated.

Journal lines

When I went _____

Who I went with _____

Where I went _____

What I will remember _____

What this page tests. *An officially designated animal that is modest rather than iconic, where the rule must hold against the reader's expectation; and a flag with an inscription and a star field, the first of the complex flags the reference section must explain.*

EGYPT

مصر

CAPITAL	Cairo
POPULATION	107.3 million
LANGUAGE	Arabic
AREA	1,001,450 km ² (386,662 sq mi)
CURRENCY	Egyptian pound (E£)

Flag. ● Red ○ White ● Black ● Gold

Flag reference section entry: *Three horizontal bands, read from the top; the gold Eagle of Saladin centered in the white band.*

Illustration. The Pyramids of Giza, in clean line for coloring.

Caption: *The Pyramids of Giza*

Why this subject (not printed): The Eagle of Saladin appears on the flag and the coat of arms, but as a heraldic emblem, not a designated national animal, so the drawing is a landmark.

Border note, printed in small type: The Halaib Triangle is administered by Egypt and claimed by Sudan. Bir Tawil, between the two, is claimed by neither.

Journal lines

When I went _____

Who I went with _____

Where I went _____

What I will remember _____

What this page tests. *A right-to-left script in the own-name line; a country that spans two continents, placed in Africa, with Sinai in Asia; a capital stated as Cairo while government moves to the New Administrative Capital; a heraldic animal that must not be mistaken for a national one; and a border note for a disputed border.*

AUSTRALIA

Commonwealth of Australia

CAPITAL	Canberra
POPULATION	27.6 million
LANGUAGE	English
AREA	7,688,287 km ² (2,968,464 sq mi)
CURRENCY	Australian dollar (A\$)

Flag. ● Blue ○ White ● Red

Flag reference section entry: *A blue field; the Union Flag in the canton; the Commonwealth Star below it and the Southern Cross at the fly, in white.*

Illustration. The Sydney Opera House, in clean line for coloring.

Caption: *The Sydney Opera House*

Why this subject (not printed): The kangaroo and the emu support the coat of arms, but neither is officially designated as a national animal, so the drawing is a landmark.

Border note, printed in small type: Australia's claim in Antarctica is not included in the area above. Territorial claims in Antarctica are held in abeyance under the Antarctic Treaty.

Journal lines

When I went _____

Who I went with _____

Where I went _____

What I will remember _____

What this page tests. *The strongest temptation in the book to assume a national animal; the second English-named country, confirming the full-official-name rule; a flag carrying another country's flag in its canton; and a note on what the area figure leaves out.*